Macapanton Abbas, Sr.

Macapanton H. Abbas, Sr. (February 1910 to August 3, 1964) was a Maranao lawyer, jurist, and public servant from Dayawan, Dansalan (now Marawi City), Lanao.

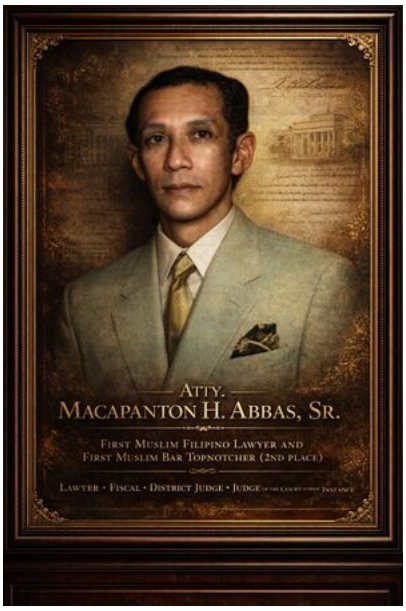
He's remembered today as the first Muslim Filipino to pass the Philippine Bar Examinations and, more remarkably, the first Muslim Filipino to place in the Top 10, finishing 2nd in his cohort. That double distinction didn't just make him a personal trailblazer; it cracked open a door that had never been opened before for the Bangsamoro people in the country's legal and judicial system.<ref name="mb2020">Template:Cite news</ref>

From the courts of Lanao del Sur to the benches of Sulu and Davao, Abbas spent his career building firsts: first Muslim fiscal, first Muslim district judge, first Muslim judge of the Court of First Instance. He served under five presidents, survived a war, lost a child to its brutality, and still came out the other side with his integrity intact. His story isn't just about a man who passed a bar exam. It's about what one person's determination can unlock for an entire people.

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Macapanton H. Abbas, Sr.



Born	February 1910 Dayawan, Dansalan (now Marawi City), Lanao
Died	August 3, 1964
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Alma mater	Philippine Law School (LL.B., 1935)
Known for	First Muslim Filipino lawyer; first Muslim Filipino to place in the Top 10 of the Philippine Bar Examinations (2nd place); first Muslim Filipino judge
Spouse	Hadja Sitti Rahma Yahya
Children	13, including Hadja Potri Zorayda Abbas, Macapanton Abbas, Jr., and Firdausi Ismail Abbas
Titles held	Justice of the Peace; First Assistant City Attorney; Provincial Fiscal; District Judge; CFI Judge

Early Life and Family

Macapanton Abbas was born in February 1910 in Dayawan, a village in Dansalan, the town that would eventually grow into Marawi City.<ref name="everybodywiki">Template:Cite web</ref>

His biological father was **Hadji Darapa Abbas**, the Datu of Marawi, and his mother was **Dalumabi**, who held the royal title of Bai-a-labi sa Dayawan, meaning she was of the royal women of that settlement.

His paternal lineage traced directly to Hadji Okur, the Rajah Muda (crown prince) of Marawi, and from him to Rampatan, the Datu of Marawi. The Abbas name carried enormous weight in Lanao; it was associated with the traditional chief ruler and defender of Marawi going back multiple generations.

Upon Macapanton's birth, he was adopted by his maternal uncle in accordance with an accepted practice in Maranao culture, where children are sometimes raised by relatives as a mark of honor and family solidarity. His adoptive father was **Sultan Cotawato of Dayawan and Wato**, the brother of his mother Dalumabi. Sultan Cotawato became popularly known as **Amai Macapanton**, meaning "Father of Macapanton," and it was through this adoption that the young Abbas grew up connected to both the Dayawan and Wato royal houses.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

Royal Lineage

Few lawyers in Philippine history came from a background as deeply rooted in traditional governance as Macapanton Abbas.

Through his biological and adoptive family lines, he held rights of succession in several of the most prominent royal houses of Lanao: Dayawan, Marantao, Marawi, Wato, Madaya, and Taraka. He was also connected to the more recently established Sultanate of Lanao, whose first Sultan was his uncle, **Ibra Gundarangin**, who also served as the first Congressman (Representative) of Lanao.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

This multi-layered royal heritage meant that Abbas moved through both indigenous political structures and the modern Philippine legal system with a foot in each world. His very name, Macapanton, was a traditional one; and the world he eventually entered as a lawyer and judge was, for most of his people, a foreign institution. He bridged both with deliberate ease.

Education

Abbas finished his elementary schooling in Dansalan, completing the basic level of formal education that was still relatively uncommon for Maranao children in the early twentieth century.

For secondary school, he traveled far from home, enrolling at the American-run **Torres High School** in Tondo, Manila. He was among the first Maranaos to complete a high school education, a distinction that in itself spoke to both his family's foresight and his own willingness to navigate an unfamiliar world far from Lake Lanao.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

He then enrolled at the **Philippine Law School**, one of the leading private law schools of the era. He completed his Bachelor of Laws (LL.B.) degree in 1935, and in the same year, he sat for and passed the Philippine Bar Examinations. He was admitted to the Philippine Bar in 1935, making him the very first Muslim Filipino lawyer in the country's history.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

The Philippine Bar Examinations: A Historic Achievement

Passing the bar was already an exceptional feat. Placing 2nd in the entire country was something else entirely.

According to records from the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), Macapanton Abbas, Sr. was the first Maranao, and the first Muslim Filipino, to place in the Top 10 of the Philippine Bar Examinations, finishing in 2nd place.<ref name="mb2020" /> No Muslim Filipino had ever come close to that kind of national ranking in the bar exams before him.

The significance of this is hard to overstate. The Philippine Bar was, and still is, one of the most competitive professional examinations in the country. For a young man from Dansalan who grew up far from Manila's law schools and libraries to place 2nd nationally was a statement. It said, clearly and without ambiguity, that the Bangsamoro mind was just as sharp, just as capable, and just as ready to lead as anyone else in the Philippine legal profession.

Abbas carried that credential with him into every courthouse and every courtroom he ever entered. It was never just a personal achievement. It was, in the words of those who followed him, the key that unlocked the door.

> "The first Maranao second placer was the late Macapanton Abbas Sr., who pulled off the feat in the 1940s on his way to becoming the country's first Muslim lawyer." — Manila Bulletin, citing National Commission on Muslim Filipinos records, May 1, 2020<ref name="mb2020" />

Student Activism and Leadership

Abbas wasn't just studying law at Philippine Law School; he was building networks and shaping ideas about what the Philippines could be.

At the law school, he joined the **Mystical Order of the Swastika**, a fraternal student organization (using the ancient symbol of good fortune, well before its later associations). He rose through its ranks to become its **Mahatma Grand Lama**, the organization's top student leader.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

More consequentially for Philippine political history, Abbas co-founded the **Young Philippines Party** alongside **Wenceslao Vinzons**, a charismatic young lawyer who would later become one of the most celebrated guerrilla commanders of World War II. The founding members of the Young Philippines Party were a remarkable group, including names that would go on to define Philippine public life: **Arturo Tolentino**, **Lorenzo Sumulong**, **Diosdado Macapagal**, **Domocao Alonto**, and **Jose Laurel Jr.**, among others.<ref name="everybodywiki" /><ref name="vinzons">Template:Cite news</ref>

Abbas was also a member of the **Nucleus Group of the Pan Malayan People's Union**, a student-led organization that sought solidarity among the peoples of the Malay Archipelago. Even as a student, he was thinking in broad, regional terms about identity, politics, and community.

Entry into the Legal Profession

After his admission to the bar in 1935, Abbas began what would become a series of historic firsts in the Philippine legal profession. He wasn't just practicing law; he was, by his very presence in each role he entered, opening that role to an entire community for the first time.

He became the first Moro First Assistant City Attorney, the first Moro Provincial Fiscal, the first Moro District Judge, and the first Moro judge of the Court of First Instance (now the Regional Trial Court). Each of these titles came with its own significance, and together they traced the arc of a career spent not just serving the law but expanding who that law could speak for and who could speak for it.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

The 1938 National Assembly Elections

Politics called Abbas early, though his first encounter with electoral politics was a painful one.

In the run-up to the 1938 Second National Assembly elections, Abbas entered the race at the last minute. His opponent was **Tomas Cabili**, a prominent figure who had served as Lanao's delegate to the 1935 Constitutional Convention. Cabili had earned tremendous goodwill among the Maranaos by refusing to sign the Constitution, the only delegate to do so, on the grounds that it failed to protect the rights of the Moro people, especially the Maranaos.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

The timing of Abbas's late entry created an awkward situation: many of his own relatives had already committed to campaign for Cabili, including his own father, Hadji Abbas, who was one of Cabili's campaign leaders. They had pledged in good faith because Abbas had earlier said he wasn't going to run.

A new block voting law heavily favored the governing Nacionalista Party, and all 98 seats of the National Assembly went to Nacionalista candidates that year. The contest between Abbas and Cabili was close, but it ended bitterly. Relatives who had pledged to the Quran to support Cabili burned the voting precinct in Dansalan, which was Abbas's own hometown. It was a wound that went deeper than any election loss.

After that experience, Abbas stepped back from electoral politics entirely. He turned, instead, to the law.

World War II: Resistance and Sacrifice

When the Japanese forces occupied the Philippines in the early 1940s, Macapanton Abbas faced the same impossible choices that every Filipino did, but with an added layer of pressure directed specifically at the Moro community.

The Japanese made deliberate efforts to recruit young Moros, framing their occupation as an opportunity to take leadership away from Christian Filipinos. Many were tempted. Abbas wasn't. He refused to collaborate, and the consequences were immediate: the Japanese placed him on a wanted list.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

What followed was a grinding, dangerous months-long flight. Abbas, his wife, his mother-in-law, four young daughters (the youngest just a few months old at the time), and their household servants moved from village to village across Lanao. They survived thanks to the Maranao tradition of hospitality rooted in the **torogan** (the royal house), where travelers, especially those of royal lineage, could find shelter. Relatives and friends opened their homes. Communities protected them.

But the war took its toll. Abbas was wounded, and the wound became infected. He needed massive doses of antibiotics to recover. And then, in the most devastating moment of those years, his youngest daughter **Salma** died. She was still an infant.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

That loss broke something. Abbas made the decision to surrender.

When he finally turned himself in, the Japanese commander did not arrest him. Instead, he offered Abbas the post of Justice of the Peace. It was, in its own way, an acknowledgment of his standing. Abbas accepted, and from that position he began rebuilding what the war had tried to destroy.

Post-War Career and Presidential Appointments

On **July 22, 1943**, Abbas was formally appointed **Justice of the Peace of the Momungan groups of municipal districts, Lanao**, by President Jose P. Laurel. He was 33 years old. It was his first judicial appointment, and it wouldn't be his last.<ref name="og1943">Template:Cite book</ref>

The appointments that followed tracked the rise of a lawyer who was consistently recognized by the country's highest executive office, across administrations and across regions.

Presidential Appointments of Macapanton H. Abbas, Sr.

Date	Position	Appointing President
July 22, 1943	Justice of the Peace, Momungan groups of municipal districts, Lanao	Jose P. Laurel
September 22, 1945	Justice of the Peace (ad interim), Tamparan, Mulundu, Taraka, Maging, Gata and Maciu, Lanao (confirmed by Commission on Appointments, October 2, 1945)	Sergio Osmeña
August 7, 1947	First Assistant City Attorney of the City of Davao (ad interim)	Manuel Roxas
August 30, 1949	Acting Provincial Fiscal of Sulu	Elpidio Quirino
June 21, 1954	District Judge, Sixteenth Judicial District of Sulu and Basilan City	Ramon Magsaysay
1956	CFI Judge of Sulu	Ramon Magsaysay
1958	CFI Judge, 2nd Branch, Davao and Davao City	Carlos P. Garcia

<ref name="og1945">Template:Cite web</ref> <ref name="og1958">Template:Cite web</ref>

Abbas served under five presidents spanning more than fifteen years of the post-war Philippine Republic, and at every step he was breaking new ground for Muslim Filipinos in the judiciary.

Campaigning for President Magsaysay

By 1953, Abbas had been serving as Provincial Fiscal of Sulu for several years. When Ramon Magsaysay entered the 1953 presidential race, Abbas made a decision that would shape both his career and the political outcome in Lanao: he resigned his post as Fiscal to campaign for Magsaysay full-time.

He returned to Lanao and united his clan behind the candidate. The result was a resounding margin: Magsaysay carried Lanao by a wide vote, in no small part because of the network Abbas had mobilized.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

Magsaysay kept faith with his supporters. In 1954, he appointed Abbas as District Judge of the Sixteenth Judicial District of Sulu and Basilan City. Two years later, in 1956, he elevated Abbas to the Court of First Instance of Sulu, the highest trial court at the time. It was the culmination of everything Abbas had worked toward: a Muslim Filipino, born in Dayawan, sitting as a judge in the country's highest trial court.

Personal Life

Macapanton Abbas married **Hadja Sitti Rahma Yahya**, a woman who was herself remarkable in her own right. She was the first Moro woman to receive her education in Cebu, where she studied from elementary through college level in the 1920s up to 1936, an extraordinary achievement for a Moro woman of that generation.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

Hadja Sitti Rahma was the daughter of **Sheikh Ismail Yahya**, from Bayang and Yemen, and **Bai Rosa Peralta**, whose family roots spanned Malita, Davao, Buayan (Cotabato), Ilocos Norte, and Yemen. She was an heiress to a hacienda in Malita, Davao that belonged to her family.

Together, Macapanton and Hadja Sitti Rahma raised thirteen children.

Their eldest daughter, **Hadja Potri Zorayda Abbas**, married **Senator Mamintal Tamano**, one of the most prominent Muslim Filipino statesmen of the twentieth century.

Their eldest son, **Macapanton Rashid Abbas, Jr.**, became a lawyer and businessman, and served as former Sultan of Dayawan.

Their second son, **Dr. Firdausi Ismail Abbas**, also became a lawyer, and holds the title of Sultan of Lanao.

The Abbas children and their descendants have continued to be significant figures in Bangsamoro civic, legal, and cultural life, a legacy directly traceable to the values their father embodied.

Legacy

Macapanton Abbas didn't set out to be a symbol. He set out to be a lawyer. But the two things turned out to be inseparable.

Before Abbas, there was no Muslim Filipino in the Philippine legal profession. There was no Muslim fiscal, no Muslim district judge, no Muslim CFI judge. The doors to those offices existed, but no one from the Bangsamoro had walked through them. Abbas walked through all of them, and in doing so, he made it possible for others to follow.

His 2nd place ranking in the Philippine Bar Examinations was particularly meaningful, not because bar rankings define a lawyer's worth, but because it demolished any lingering assumption that Muslim Filipinos couldn't compete at the highest levels of national professional life. In a country where the legal system was built largely around Christian Filipino political and social norms, Abbas's ranking was an argument, made in numbers, that the Bangsamoro people belonged in that system and could excel within it.<ref name="mb2020" />

The National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) counts Abbas among the most consequential figures in the history of Muslim Filipino participation in Philippine public life. His daughter's marriage into the Tamano family, and his sons' continuation of the legal profession, suggest that the values he modeled were transmitted not just through stories but through lived example.

Death

Macapanton H. Abbas, Sr. died on **August 3, 1964**. He was in his mid-fifties, leaving behind a family of thirteen children, a distinguished judicial career, and a legacy that the Bangsamoro legal community still looks to as a foundational chapter in its history.<ref name="everybodywiki" />

He had spent nearly three decades in public service, surviving a world war, political defeat, personal tragedy, and the isolation that came with being always the first of his kind in every room he entered. He did it with the bearing of a man who knew exactly who he was, where he came from, and what he owed to the people he represented.

Further Reading

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- Dooc, Emmanuel. "Wenceslao Q. Vinzons: The Hero the Nation Forgot." *Business Mirror*, September 26, 2019.
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See Also

- Bangsamoro
- Maranao people
- Marawi City
- Philippine Bar Examinations
- Domocao Alonto
- Mamintal Tamano
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Court of First Instance
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao

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